wouldn’t have been difficult for Honecker to obtain a gun or a poison ampoule in Moscow and bid a ‘manly farewell’. ‘He would have had good press; tears would have flowed, and the German constitutional state would have been booed. Kinkel and Kohl would be considered bounty hunters. That would have been a more exciting political spectacle than the tough, meticulous days of litigation that will now follow.’3 In closing, it asserted the former General Secretary would be the last of the Mohicans to defend the GDR. ‘An acquittal for a lack of evidence would be like a slap in the face for the East Germans. Justice should take its course. Even if the accused will not show a trace of remorse.’4

On the morning of 30 July, though he needed rest and recuperation, Honecker shuffled into ‘Room 500’ at Tiergarten court in prison trousers, a white shirt and a grey jacket and was arraigned on forty-nine counts of manslaughter, he made no statement. The trial was expected to start in November.

As this was happening, Margot was on the move. ‘I want nothing but my peace, and a few nice days with my grandson and daughter,’ she told reporters in the lobby of Moscow airport before departing for Santiago. Though her marital spirit was unwavering, German media portrayed a woman abandoning her man in his most desperate hour. In an appalling full-page spread, Bild even cobbled together a series of vox-pops from the public to add colourful chunks of moral outrage. ‘I would never desert my husband, no matter what happened,’ indignant businesswoman Hieke Werbelow told the tabloid. ‘That she did is typical.’ Similarly, pensioner Lisbeth Reinsch declared Margot must not be a good wife, ‘she deserted her husband, even though she is as guilty as he is’.5

Over at Moabit, doctors discovered Honecker’s tumour had metastasised, prompting his lawyers to unsuccessfully appeal for him to be released until his trial. He was, though, moved to a private cell, containing a mirror, a square of carpet, an electric fire and a wooden table. Apart from treating his existing ailments, Honecker did not bother the prison medics unduly, except for the occasional sleeping tablet. ‘Yesterday I was lucky enough to see Erich Mielke after such a long time,’ he scribbled in a notepad. ‘A nurse accompanied him on a tour of the yard. I called him from upstairs. No